

The Effectiveness of a Nurse-Led ED Discharge Checklist in Improving Patient Readiness and Ensuring Safe, Efficient Discharge from the Emergency Department

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INTRODUCTION

The Emergency Department (ED) experiences a high patient turnover, further intensified by winter pressures, population growth, and limited hospital bed capacity. As a result, many patients remain in the ED longer than intended, often receiving ongoing care or being discharged directly from specialty teams.

This project explored the impact of implementing a nurse-led discharge checklist to support efficient and safe patient discharge. The aim was to enhance discharge readiness, reduce ED length of stay, and minimise overnight social admissions caused by transport delays or unavailability. The project also sought to improve ED flow and capacity, enhance quality of care, and uphold the Trust's values of being safe, kind, and excellent.

AIM

The purpose of the project is to measure the effectiveness of a nurse discharge checklist in ED.

METHODOLOGY

A nurse-led discharge checklist was implemented in the Emergency Department using an EPIC smart phrase on 18/11/2025. Awareness was supported through posters, workstation cue cards, emails, and handovers.

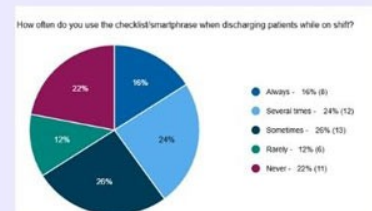
Three weeks later, a survey assessing usability and effectiveness was conducted (07/01/2026–14/10/2026) among 50 ED nurses, achieving a 100% response rate.

FINDINGS



94% of nursing staff were aware of the discharge checklist, while 3% (n=6) were not.

This indicates strong overall communication, with only a small remaining education gap likely among newer or less frequent users.



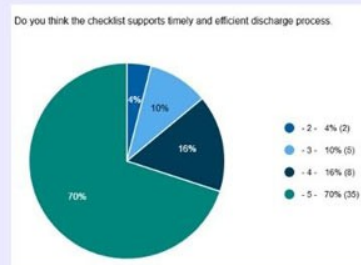
Over a third of staff admitted to occasionally using the checklist. Adoption gap is evident.

Two-thirds use the checklist at least occasionally, consistent use is low. Potential barriers for using the checklist are time constraints, lack of awareness and high acuity as per their verbal feedback.

Results showed high confidence in the ED nursing discharge checklist ensuring safe patient discharge.

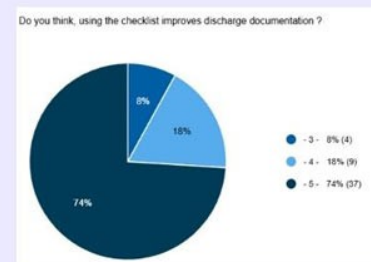
94% of respondents agreed or strongly agreed that it improves discharge safety (mean score 4.68/5), with only 6% neutral or less convinced.

The checklist is widely accepted and well integrated into clinical practice, with minimal staff concerns.



86% agree that the checklist supports timely and efficient discharge.

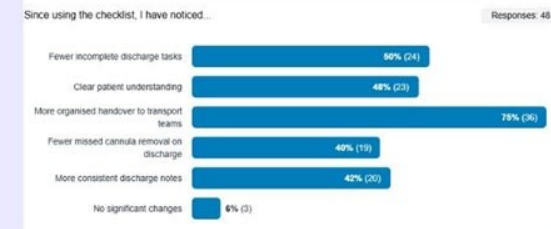
While a small proportion were neutral or disagreed, suggesting the checklist may not fully address all workflow challenges.



Do you think the checklist improves patient readiness at time of discharge? Responses: 50, Average: 4.68



More than half of the respondents believed the checklist improves patient readiness at time of discharge, 4% (20) were neutral and 2% (1) disagreed.



The checklist is perceived as highly effective, improving communication, documentation consistency, and patient safety during discharge.

The low proportion reporting no change strengthens the case that the checklist delivers real, practical benefits the department.

Analysis

The discharge checklist was well received, with staff reporting improvements in safe, efficient discharge and clearer nursing documentation. It also acted as a helpful reminder for key tasks—such as cannula removal and ensuring ReSPECT forms were completed—supporting better discharge readiness.

Although evaluated over six weeks, the positive impact suggests that integrating the checklist directly into EPIC could further enhance safe and effective ED discharge at scale.

References

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